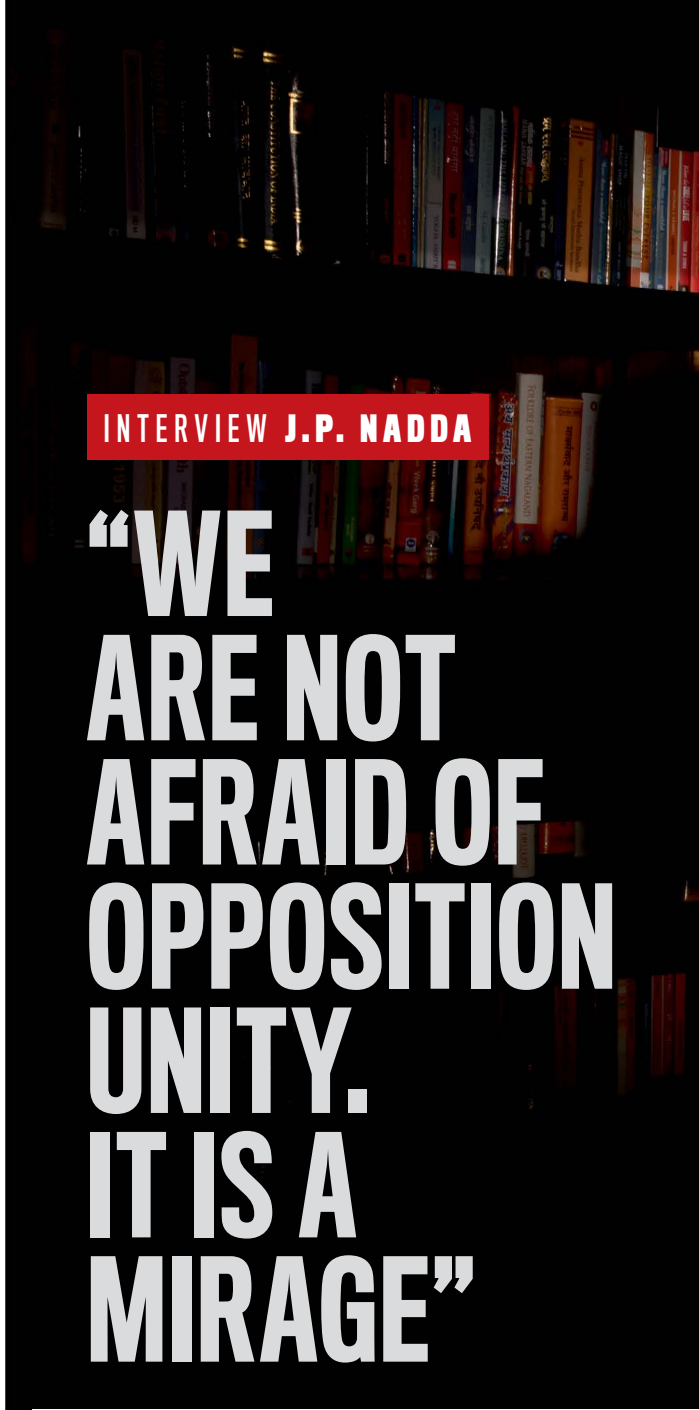
dia is said to be facing a challenge in his stronghold in the Gwalior-Chambal region with some of the Congress leaders who had defected with him returning to the Grand Old Party. In Rajasthan, where the Congress is clearly on the backfoot, the BJP is yet to sort out the leadership issue with Vasundhara Raje remaining a powerful force. It has also failed in its efforts to split the Congress party (as it did in Madhya Pradesh), with Sachin Pilot deciding against defecting or forming a party of his own.

THE SIX SIGMA

Overall, the BJP is focusing on six major planks to win the elections. Projecting the Opposition as fragile and corrupt, both in the states and at the Centre, is the first plank—meant to morally decimate them. The second is the BJP's development plank where, with its massive organisation, it has reached out to 12 million households to convince them of the Modi government's achievements in the past nine years. To help create a buzz, 44 Union ministers and top party leaders have also been put on the job. It has also made a database of 450 million social scheme beneficiaries or *labharthis* and is reaching out to them individually through booth-level workers. The third is that it is depending on the reliable plank of hypernationalism to bolster its support as it did in 2019. Psephologist Kumar believes that apart from claiming credit for abrogating Article 370 in J&K, "the BJP's trump card" is to push for legislation on the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Parliament. The demand is likely to get majoritarian support as it is bound to create divisions among the minorities. It could put the Opposition on the backfoot.

All this dovetails neatly into its fourth major plank of Hindutva, where the BJP will showcase itself as the defender of the faith with the inauguration of the first phase of the Ram temple in Ayodhya in January 2024. The fifth and possibly the most important plank would be Prime Minister Modi himself and his immense popularity and the faith that India's voters have bestowed on him. The BJP will push to make the 2024 election a presidential race of Modi versus the rest. Nadda believes the Modi government's performance in the second term has given the country the momentum to become a developed country in the near future. The sixth plank is the promise to the voters that the BJP government headed by the charismatic Modi is pushing for a "Viksit Bharat"—a developed nation, when India completes 100 years of independence. On the strength of all its manoeuvres so far, the BJP appears to be in pole position to win the 2024 general election. ■

–with Bureau reports



INTERVIEW **J.P. NADDA**

"WE ARE NOT AFRAID OF OPPOSITION UNITY. IT IS A MIRAGE"

With four major state elections to be held later this year and the 2024 Lok Sabha polls less than a year away, BJP president J.P. NADDA's schedule is packed with back-to-back party meetings. Despite that, the affable Nadda took time out to speak to Group Editorial Director RAJ CHENGAPPA